

Right from the start, you know the program means business. It informs you that if you remove spybots (Spybot's term for spyware applications) from your computer, you may not be able to use the host programs that the spybots were bundled with.

Spybot's interface is very functional; there's a toolbar on the left, and details on the main screen at the right. You can choose to view the Default mode or the Advanced mode. The Advanced mode offers several extra options such as IE tweaks, Secure Shredder, etc.

After scanning your system, Spybot lists out the harmful entries on your computer so you have an idea of what exactly is going on. You can check the entries you wish to delete, and if you're unsure about what to do, the software will give you a few options and a detailed explanation of what the entry is, along with a recommendation. One feature is that if you decide to keep the adware on your computer, you have the option of excluding it from further scans. You can also instruct the software to exclude a host of other components that you may feel like keeping on your computer, such as cookies.

Spybot, like we mentioned, has a lot of functions that are absent in Ad-Aware, such as the "exclude" functionality. One of the best options Spybot offers is in the Immunize menu. This allows you "immunise" your browsers to malicious content, so that a spyware program, once removed, is not allowed to enter your computer again later.

4.4.3 HijackThis

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Before we discuss what HijackThis is and what it does, we need to have an idea of what essentially a browser hijack is. A browser hijacker, as the name suggests, is a form of malware that "hijacks" your Web browser and displays tons of pop-up ads one after the other. It replaces the existing start page, search page or error page of your browser with ones of its own. This results in